

Epistemology

Kind reader, permit me to suggest that the matter of epistemology has not received the attention it deserves within the discipline of NT textual criticism. Epistemology deals with the nature of knowledge, including origin and foundations. Where does knowledge come from? “The fear of the Lord is the beginning of knowledge” (Proverbs 1:7). Is that correct? It can only be correct if the Sovereign Creator exists—to fear a nonexistent being will not result in true knowledge. Any evolutionist will naturally exclude the supernatural from any model that he creates, as did Fenton John Anthony Hort. Note that such a model does not allow for the possibility of a divinely inspired NT. The evolutionary hypothesis, as a theory of origins, is scientifically impossible; the evidence that surrounds us clearly points to the existence of an incredibly intelligent and powerful Creator.

If the Creator exists, and if He has delivered a written Revelation to our race, nothing should be more important to us than to know what He said. Of course, because He will be the Source of all true knowledge. Stop and think. If some Being created our planet with all it contains, including all forms of life (plants have life), and especially including our ability to reason,¹ He is obviously competent to give us correct information about what He created. He is the Source of objective truth about our planet. How do we ‘know’ anything? Only if we have experienced it, or if someone else has experienced it and tells us about it. But what happens if experiences conflict? And how can we know if or when we interpret an experience correctly? And how can we handle conflicting interpretations?

If there is no Creator to give us correct information, our ‘knowledge’ is condemned to be always partial and uncertain, when not dangerously mistaken. This is equally true for those who pretend that there is no Creator. The despair of relativism and unrelenting uncertainty about everything that is not hard science is the result. King Solomon was smart enough to figure that out 3,000 years ago: “Vanity of vanities, all is vanity!” (Ecclesiastes 1:2).

Satan has been filling the world with sophistries for 6,000 years, so there is no end of fake ‘knowledge’ out there—not least in the ‘science’ of NT textual criticism. For someone who claims to be a Christian to exclude the supernatural from his working model is to involve himself in a fundamental epistemological contradiction. He claims to be a Christian, but he works like an atheist. Anyone who excludes the supernatural from his

¹ Remember Descartes? “I think, therefore I am.”